GOING NOWHERE: LION TRANSLOCATION THROUGH THE DECADES

1957: Three lions from a zoo translocated to Chandraprabha sanctuary near Varanasi in UP. After steady increase, they slowly die out

October 1979: The Gujarat government writes to the Centre to find alternative habitats for the Asiatic lion

1995: Kuno sanctuary identified as most suitable for lion translocation. Other habitats discussed are Sita Mata, Darrah sanctuaries in Rajasthan

1998-2000: 24 villages with 1,545 families from the Sahariya community, Gurjars and Yadavs are moved out of Kuno to create an inviolate habitat for lions

August 2020: Project Lion announced; identifies six new lion sanctuaries—two in MP (Gandhi Sagar, Madhav), three in Rajasthan (Sita Mata, Kumbhalgarh, Mukundra) and one in Gujarat (Jessore-Balaram Ambaji)

Sept. 2022-Feb.2023: Eight cheetahs are brought to Kuno from Namibia; later 12 brought from South Africa

March 2023: MoEFCC tells SC that lions can't be brought to Kuno as cheetahs are already there. Relook of lion translocation project in six months

A vision for Amrutkal', talks about developing the Barda-Alech Hills and the coastal forests as part of a long-term vision for lion conservation and assesses that it has a carrying capacity of 40 adult and sub-adult lions. "Unlike Gir," says Nityanand Srivastava, chief wildlife warden of Gujarat, "this is an open forest area with pockets developed as a *vidi* (grassland). Up to two lions have naturally migrated there. They are radio-collared, we are monitoring them. We are confident that this region will emerge as a preferred habitat for lions. The water and flora-fauna ecosystem for the herbivore prey base is sufficient."

Wildlife experts, however, are of the opinion that while moving 40 lions to Barda is a welcome temporary measure, it does not constitute a long-term solution. "The Barda region is contiguous with the existing lion population, so it does not mitigate the risks to the species due to natural calamities or infectious diseases. Nor does it help resolve the human-lion conflict. So, what is Barda seen as a solution for?" asks Bengaluru-based Ravi Chellam, wildlife biologist and conservation scientist. Y.V. Jhala, former dean at the WII, says, "We have to use genetically diverse lions as founders of a new population established far from the Saurashtra landscape. Within Gujarat, the wildlife sactuaries of Jessore and Balaram along with forests of Ambaji and Shaymalaji are ideal after some incentivised village relocation. Lions should be brought back to all parts of India where they historically used to roam," he adds.

This is not the first time that Barda has come up as an alternative habitat for lions. It was among the five sites that were assessed during a 1993 workshop on the Population and Habitat Viability Assessment of the Asiatic Lion. Barda had then come up short on account of water, prey and forage scarcity, besides encroachment. Other wildlife sanctuaries—Kumbhalgarh, Sitamata, Darrah Jawahar Sagar—did not make the cut either, whether for inadequate prey base, unsuitable terrain or human interference, and Kuno Palpur was found to be the most suitable place for relocation.

To welcome the new guests, the state of Madhya Pradesh had in fact set up a separate wildlife division for Kuno, increasing the protected area for wildlife to 1,269 square kilometres. A suitable prey base was also prepared. Some 1,545 families of the Sahariya tribes in 24 villages were relocated. However, when the time came to shift the lions, in 2006, the Gujarat government refused, saying the lions were perfectly fine where they were and translocation would put them under pressure. They also said Kuno had an inadequate prey base for lions, and that MP did not have a good record in protecting its tigers at the Panna reserve.

Tired of the continued objections of the Gujarat government, the Supreme Court on April 16, 2013, categorically ruled in favour of lion relocation to Kuno. But still the state kept stalling the proposition, and the lions kept staying on in Gir. It was in this context that PM Modi's Project Lion appeared to be a step forward. The objective remained much the same—to manage growing lion populations, secure and manage lion habitats and mitigate human-lion conflict. Among proposed activities were habitat augmentation, development of peripheral forests and lion corridors. The 'Lion@2047: A vision for Amrutkal' document also advocated the creation of additional free-ranging lion populations in Gujarat and elsewhere. But, strangely, it did not mention the six sites outlined in the PM's plans. Highly-placed sources claim that these sites



"RISKS TO LIONS FROM NATURAL DISASTERS AND DISEASES REMAIN IN BARDA AS IT LIES NEAR EXISTING LION POPULATION"

–RAVI CHELLAM
Conservation scientist